Dibang River catchment. To the south, a third range hems in the sector, giving the tract a bowl-like appearance from the air.

The surrounding hills around the Lohit River Valley are a maze of spurs, their ridges separating innumerable small streams that flow into the main body of the Lohit. The ridges slope down to either flank of the river, creating lateral natural defensive barriers against any intruding enemy. Each one of these spurs was of tremendous tactical value. With a 2 Assam Rifles post guarding the immediate border at Kibithu, the Indians could optimize their defensive capability considerably by developing delaying defences on these features.

This natural advantage was, however, offset by the logistical difficulties of moving men and supplies into the area. The deadly earthquake of 1950 had decimated the existing primitive trails that existed in the region. In addition, the Lohit Frontier Division was covered with thick forests; dense bamboo forests in the lower reaches give way to broad-leaved evergreen tall trees. As the altitude increases, oak, rhododendron and pine take over, before the advent of spruce and juniper forests in the immediate vicinity of Kibithu.

In the 1860s and 1870s, Captain Cooper had tried to open a trade route to China but had failed. In 1910, a Chinese general had forced the local Mishmi to construct a road to India following the alignment of the Lohit River, but after days of hard labour, gave up the attempt. This resulted in the Rima track being the main line of communication. It ran along the right bank of the Lohit, connecting the Assam plains with Hayuliang with Manikaran and Walong. Steep and narrow, it was difficult going for even pack animals, as many bamboo stairways had to be negotiated before getting to Kibithu. The distance from Walong to Kibithu was thirty kilometres, and from there, the McMahon Line was five kilometres further to the north. Beyond the frontier were two Tibetan villages, Sama and Tattoo, after which lay Rima, a Tibetan administrative base.

On the opposite side of the river was another, more difficult track. In the lower reaches, the gradient was extremely steep and owing to the thick jungles, it was seldom used. Across the river from Walong was a small hamlet called Tinai and further north lay the villages of Dong and Kahoo, the latter being in the Di Chu Valley. Eventually, this track would link up with the western track at Rima. Apart from these two routes, a third track entered the Lohit Frontier Division from Tazung Dam. This track after